

The Effect of Learner Training on the Use of Digital Tools to Support English Writing Skills

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Abstract

This paper investigates the effects of learner training for CALL general use tools on students whose digital literacy is lower than that assumed by the New Zealand university system they are preparing to enter. Previous studies have found that computers offer multiple benefits for teaching and learning writing skills. The use of word processors can offer writing support of various types, can give automatic corrective feedback to the writer and can stimulate collaborative learning. However, language learners are often unable to fully utilize the potential of word processors in developing their writing skills due to a lack of knowledge and training in using these tools effectively. International students may have lower levels of experience in using technology than the New Zealand students they study with. In this descriptive study, eight English for academic purposes (EAP) students from China, Japan, Chile and Brazil participated, each with their own set of experiences and expectations of technology. The effects of training on learners' awareness and use of the writing support features available in Microsoft Office Word was explored using a mixed method approach. After training, learners reported feeling more confident about using computers for writing.

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Introduction

As connectivity, technical sophistication and access to technology have continued to increase, so has the expectation that technology will be used as a natural part of teaching and learning by new cohorts of students entering language classrooms. The assumption is that these are tech-savvy and digitally literate learners (Lavin, Korte & Davies, 2011). This applies at both tertiary and lower levels. Much research on the introduction of technology to language learning was carried out in the 1990s when schools in many countries began to get access to computers (Warschauer, 1996). Later, technology continued to develop, but digital literacy has come and gone as a curriculum goal. The TESOL organisation set out its Technology Standards Framework for teachers and learners in 2008 (TESOL, 2008), taking basic computer skills in teachers and learners for granted. Consequently, the importance of technology-enhanced classrooms also escalated and today, most students see the use of technology in classrooms as an integral part of their learning.

As Godwin-Jones (2016) pointed out, basic digital competence is generally assumed now in new students at university, at least in countries like New Zealand where high-school graduates are expected to have been using technology as long as they can remember (Prensky, 2001). However, the use of digital tools is not homogeneous all over the world; the International Telecommunication Union (2017) recently reported a continuing wide gap in the use of the Internet among major regions of the world. In Africa only 21.8% of the total population was using the Internet, whereas this proportion was much higher in Asia (43.9%) and Europe (79.6%). As education is becoming more and more global, with institutions gathering students from all over the world, this digital gap can hinder the process of attaining learning outcomes of programs with culturally diverse students. This problem is particularly significant in the case of New Zealand which hosts a substantial number of international students every year. In 2016, New Zealand hosted 102,535 international students at tertiary level, largely coming from Asia, Europe and Latin America (Education Counts, 2017).

As a result, it cannot be assumed that incoming international students in a cohort will be fully aware of and skillful in the use of basic digital tools for education-related purposes. This fact becomes crucial for institutions, administrators and teachers expecting students to attain individual as well as institutional educational goals. A possible solution to this situation can be training the language learners in using basic writing tools. O'Bryan (2008) pointed out that

even minimal training can go a long way. The present study employs a mixed method approach in order to explore the effects of training on students' awareness of and ability to use generic tools such as Microsoft Office Word (henceforth MS Word) to enhance their English writing skills in the New Zealand context. Furthermore, it also explores the attitudes and perceptions of these students in the use of technology for learning the English language.

Literature review

The use of computers for writing has been shown to offer many benefits to language learners of various ages. Early work (e.g. Warschauer, 1996), found the novelty of the use of computers for writing to motivate learners. Some work has focused on particular tools within word processors (Sauro, 2009; Ulusoy, 2006), such as supplying prompts for the writers, making spelling mistakes visible, making the editing of work easy, as well as more advanced features, such as speech recognition, audio feedback, and word prediction, etc. The use of these features has mostly been studied in the context of learning disabilities or teaching primary literacy (Williams, 2002). Several researchers identified some time ago that the use of word processors can stimulate collaborative writing, which results in higher cognizance of the writing process in language learners (Crook, 1994; Snyder, 1994; Salomon, Kosminsky & Asaf, 2004). Language learners who are grappling with a new script may be well served by being allowed to use word processors for their writing (Zhu, Shum, Tse, & Liu, 2016 working on overseas learners of Chinese). However, as Prensky (2001) pointed out, the effectiveness of technology is directly related to the users' knowledge of technological tools, and their expertise and level of comfort while using these tools.

For those who are used to having access to a computer, it seems obvious that it is better to write using a word processor. However, this is not necessarily the experience of all learners. Xu and Ding (2014) explored what Chinese tertiary learners of English as a foreign language actually did while writing on the computer and found differences in the pause patterns in writing between the skilled writers and the less skilled. The skilled writers, 11 students in all, scored higher in the writing test while the less skilled writers, 13 students, scored much lower. Screen and input capture software was used to capture students' computer activity. The results showed that the skilled writers spent less time on pre-writing stages and paused less frequently but for longer times during this stage. However, the two groups did not have any differences in terms of pause frequency and pause duration during their actual writing. In addition, the skilled writers used web searches in English during their pre-writing, whereas both groups used bilingual dictionaries during the actual process. Xu and Ding (2014) found

out that the less skilled writers used dictionaries more often to compensate for their linguistic deficiencies.

Previous work looking at the use of word processors with spelling and grammar checks has found them poorly adapted for learners to use, as they are intended for native speakers of the target language who have implicit knowledge of correct forms to fall back on. Gupta (1998) found that students in Singapore using early word processors managed to locate and correct some of their spelling errors; and they also used the spelling checker to generate words that were in their receptive but not in their productive vocabularies. Working on German as a target language, Rimrott and Heift (2005) found that MS Word (as used in 2003) missed almost half of the learners' errors. They suggested training learners to understand that undetected words are not necessarily correct and that the target word is not necessarily in the list of alternatives provided by the spell checker. They also suggested using a dictionary as a complement to a spell checker. Even with immediate or instant feedback, students using more recent software did not always use or trust the feedback they were given (Shintani & Aubrey, 2016). This was also the case with an iCALL grammar checker intended for learners (Lavolette, Polio & Kahng, 2015). However, a carefully crafted iCALL approach targeting just four problematic structures for Korean students of English (Cowan, Choo & Lee 2014) showed significant and lasting improvement.

Hubbard (2004) described CALL environments as powerful learning environments and argued that learners must be prepared adequately in order to learn in these environments. CALL environments offer significant self-learning opportunities to the learners, which can yield negative results if learners exhibit lack of technical, strategic and pedagogical skills. Distraction from the enormous amount of information available on the Internet, a lack of necessary support structures, the hidden costs of available resources, web-advertising, a lack of systematization and limited quality control are some of the constraints associated with CALL (Reinders & White, 2010). Besides effective use of multimedia, recognising and evaluating new opportunities, and getting appropriate feedback are some of the major challenges faced by language learners. To cope with these constraints and challenges, learners need more practice, preparation, feedback and support to gain adequate benefit from technology (Reinders & Hubbard, 2013). Nonetheless, Hubbard (2013) pointed out a disconnection between learners' ability to deal comfortably with general-use tools and their use for language learning.

O'Bryan (2008) argued that traditional CALL training was more focused on enabling language learners to complete certain tasks and less on the pedagogical development of

learners, which negatively affected the development of learner autonomy, hence hindering the process of building successful learning experiences. Although learner training focusing on procedural details and completing CALL tasks without the help of the instructor has its own benefits, an understanding of the pedagogical principles of the development of CALL materials and activities can foster language learning autonomy (O'Bryan, 2008). Several researchers have pointed out that the main goal of CALL training must be to create autonomous users of technology, which can be achieved by providing both technical and strategic training to the learners (Healey, 2007; Hubbard, 2004; Shetzer & Warschauer, 2000).

Reinders and Hubbard (2013) distinguished between direct and indirect teaching of the knowledge and necessary skills involved in this process of building learner autonomy. Reinders (2006) argued that learners needed specific training in regards to using these resources as well as the skills required for self-directed learning. In the self-study context, learners are not always successful in shaping their learning experiences and need extensive preparation, ongoing guidance and follow-up support to avail of the complete benefits of CALL resources (Darasawang & Reinders, 2010; Reinders, 2006).

The present study aims to contribute to our understanding of the effects of learner training by considering the relationship between students' previous experience of using technology, their ability to quickly learn to use the technology and to develop their academic writing through training in MS Word. This study employed a mixed method approach. Students' responses were explored to assess whether providing technical, strategic and pedagogical training (Hubbard, 2004) in using MS Word influenced their awareness of the software's affordances and their own practices to enhance their English writing skills. The study addresses the following research question:

How does learner training influence the EAP students' awareness and use of writing aids made available in MS Word?

Prior to training the learners, it was considered important to look into their previous digital practices both for academic and non-academic purposes. It was assumed that the digital practices of these learners were based on their individual expertise in using digital tools included in software such as MS Word, and that this may not be sufficient to gain maximum benefit.

Method

The research context and the participants

The study was carried out over a one-week course at a language college in New Zealand. The college offers English for Academic Purposes (EAP-1 and EAP-2) courses to students who need to improve their academic English skills for tertiary studies in New Zealand. Students registering for these courses study English for 30 hours per week, comprised of 20 hours of study in the classroom, five hours of self-study, and five hours of online study. Successful completion of these preparatory EAP courses allows students to fulfil the English language requirement to secure admission to undergraduate and graduate programs at university level in New Zealand without taking an IELTS exam. The participants in this study belonged to an EAP-2 group and had been studying English at the college for 3 weeks when the study began.

Initially nineteen students volunteered to participate in the study. These students completed a survey and a free-writing about their use of technology for different purposes with special focus on learning English. Eight of these students completed the one-week training programme, provided writing samples and took part in pre- and post-training interviews. Demographic information about these students is given below:

Table 1 *Participants' demographic information*

Participants	Gender	Age	Nationality	Time spent on digital devices per week	Time spent on digital devices for study purposes per week
Student 1	Male	21	Brazilian	5 hours	3 hours
Student 2	Female	40	Chilean	5 hours	2 hours
Student 3	Female	23	Japanese	2 -6 hours	5 hours
Student 4	Female	40	Chinese	2 hours	1 hour
Student 5	Male	23	Brazilian	More than 7 hours	4 hours
Student 6	Male	24	Brazilian	5 hours	5 hours
Student 7	Female	20	Brazilian	9 hours	7 hours
Student 8	Female	21	Brazilian	6 hours	5 hours

Research design

The study was descriptive in nature, involving pre- and post-training interviews and free-writing, a survey about digital practices and the training sessions. The object of the training programme was for participants to learn how to use some of the writing support tools available in MS Word: Grammar, Synonyms, Thesaurus, Spell check, Translation and Text-to-speech. Of course, there are other better tools, including those created specifically for language learners (see e.g. Lawley (2015) for a selection), but none were at the learners' immediate disposal.

After receiving the students' informed consent to participate, the survey, free-writing and pre-interviews were carried out. This is referred to as Day 0 as it preceded the five training days. The students preferred using their own computers, hence, instead of using screen capture or other features to record how students used MS Word features to fix their writing mistakes, a pen & paper version was included in the research design. On the first training day, students were asked to write a short text using pen and paper and then to type the text into MS Word, using any features they happened to be familiar with such as text to speech, translation, grammar and spell check, thesaurus, and synonyms to fix any writing mistakes they found. The two text versions were compared to get an understanding of students' pre-existing awareness of MS Word. On the following three days, after an introduction to the writing support features, students practiced utilizing these tools in daily in-class writing assignments. These practice assignments were created to help students concentrate on using MS Word to improve their writing. Finally, on day five, when students had become familiar with the selected digital tools, they were asked to give a second writing sample by writing a paragraph with pen and paper. Later, they used MS Word to improve the paragraph. All the student texts, both pen-and-paper and MS Word versions were collected. The post-training interviews were conducted a week after the students had completed their post-training writing. The following table summarises the research design:

Table 2*Research design*

	Research Design
Pre-Training	Surveys about digital practices Free-writing Pre-training interviews
Training	Pre-training pen and paper writing Pre-training MS Word writing Five-day training was provided
Post-Training	Post-training pen and paper writing Post-training MS Word writing Post-training interviews

Data collection tools and analysis

Free writing: The participants were asked to write about their views on the use of technology for different purposes with a special focus on learning the English language. This writing was done in English but was not analysed for language-related issues; rather, qualitative data were extracted based on students' expressed perceptions and beliefs about the use of technology in learning English.

Survey: As the students were from different countries and had different educational and technological experiences, it was considered of interest to know about their current use and aspirations for the future use of technology. A modified version of the SEET questionnaire (Gosper, McKenzie, Pizzica, Malfroy, & Ashford-Rowe, 2013) which was originally designed for tertiary students in Australia, was employed to elicit information about students' attitudes, beliefs and practices of technologies. The questionnaire had three parts. The first part aimed to explore the digital tools that students had access to and used for various purposes. The second part investigated how students employed technology for various educational purposes; students were asked to indicate their current practices and future preferences in the use of technology for learning and communicating with teaching staff and other students for study-related purposes. Students' current practices were measured on a Likert scale: *Never or Rarely, A few times a week, One or more times a day*, whereas Yes/No questions were asked to measure their future preferences in the use of technology. Two open-ended questions were added in this section to learn about any other technologies the students desired to use for educational purposes. Students were also asked to explain why they wanted to use these tools. The third and final part involved demographic information such as age,

gender, education level and the amount of time students spent using digital tools each week.

Pre- and post-training writing: The pre- and post-training pen and paper and MS Word writing samples were used to investigate whether students had gained any benefits from the training in the work of their texts. The topic for both samples was the same: students wrote a paragraph on what they were doing outside of class to improve their English writing skills.

Interviews: The pre- and post-training interviews were conducted to get in-depth knowledge of participants' use of MS Word and of their beliefs about the role of MS Word in their study. The pre-training interviews were conducted in groups of 4-5 students with all 19 participants who volunteered to participate on Day 0; and an interview took fifteen minutes on average to complete. Later, the post-training interviews were carried out in pairs with the eight students who had completed all the activities related to the study. These interviews were conducted a week after the end of the training, and each took about ten minutes to complete.

Training

In the present study, Hubbard's (2004) principles of learner training and Romeo and Hubbard's (2010) model of training were adopted. Hubbard (2004) pointed out that preparing learners to use effective strategies in a CALL environment increases the effective use of technological tools for language learning and it also improves participants' ability to support their learning objectives through utilizing multiple strategies (Romeo and Hubbard, 2010). The training session was based on three interlinked and sometimes overlapping categories (Romeo & Hubbard, 2010): 1) Technical Training, 2) Strategic Training, and 3) Pedagogical Training. It was argued that once the technical skills were acquired, they could be focused with strategic skills to lead towards the development and improvement of pedagogical skills.

Technical Training: Romeo and Hubbard (2010) argued that the effective use of a CALL application was directly related to the user's knowledge of, and ability to use, the application. Since the initial interviews showed that the participants had limited knowledge of MS Word, the first step of the intervention was to provide technical training. The technical training consisted of preparing the participants to connect to the University Wi-Fi in order to access the online features of MS Word, changing the language of the MS Word application from their mother tongue to English, etc. Along with these, six specific language support features of MS Word were introduced to the participants: Grammar, Synonyms, Thesaurus, Spell check, Translation and Text-to-speech.

Strategic Training: The strategic training for the participants was focused on how to use the above mentioned six features of MS Word to improve their writing skills using cognitive,

meta-cognitive and socio-affective strategies (Romeo & Hubbard, 2010). Small exercises, such as writing an alternative word for a highlighted word, were designed to provide strategy training to the participants, about 15 minutes for each of the target MS Word features. Five sentences, in total, were given as an exercise each day. These sentences and words were selected to suit the English proficiency level of the participants; and they provided ample challenges and opportunities for the participants to use all the features of MS Word that were in focus in the study. The participants were also trained to utilize cognitive strategies to directly manipulate the information, by using the Translate and Synonym features of MS Word and meta-cognitive strategies, involving using the thesaurus, lookup and dictionary features to find and choose a suitable alternative for the highlighted words. Socio-affective strategies were trained by discussing and explaining their choices of words to their fellow participants.

Pedagogical Training: In order to provide pedagogical training to the learners, Hubbard's (2004) five principles were adopted. These principles and their realisation in this context are explained in Table 3.

Table 3

Pedagogical training based on Hubbard's (2004) principles of learner training

Principles	Execution
<i>Experience CALL yourself</i>	The writing support tools in MS Word were used by the trainers themselves prior to the study, keeping in mind the objective of improving the English writing skills.
<i>Give learners teacher training</i>	Learners were provided with general advice on how MS Word can be used to improve English writing skills and were told that they would be introduced to the tools and given an opportunity to practise using them with the aim of becoming autonomous users of the tools.
<i>Use a cyclic approach</i>	Training was provided in small chunks starting on the second day of the study. Then each subsequent day, learners were given a summary and review of previous training.
<i>Use collaborative debriefings</i>	Learners shared their experiences with their peers and employed strategies which they had learned in the previous sessions.
<i>Teach general exploitation strategies</i>	Participants generalized the strategies and used them in their own writings while using MS Word. They were also debriefed about how they can use these skills to improve their academic writing in their future tertiary studies.

Research Findings

Students' digital practices

Analysis of the survey data allowed us to describe the digital practices of the EAP students. Since these students had different educational backgrounds and technological skills, it was necessary to get information about students' digital practices before providing them with training in the use of MS Word. The survey results showed that the most common devices among students were a computer at home and personal smartphones. E-book readers and tablets were the least common devices as can be seen in Figure 1. Figure 1 also shows the differences between the tools participants have access to, the tools they use often, and those they use often. All but one of the participants had a computer (usually a laptop) at home, but less than a third of them wanted to use that laptop in the college. While all participants had access to college computers, this was not a popular option either. The only devices many of the participants wanted to use while at college were their smart phones.

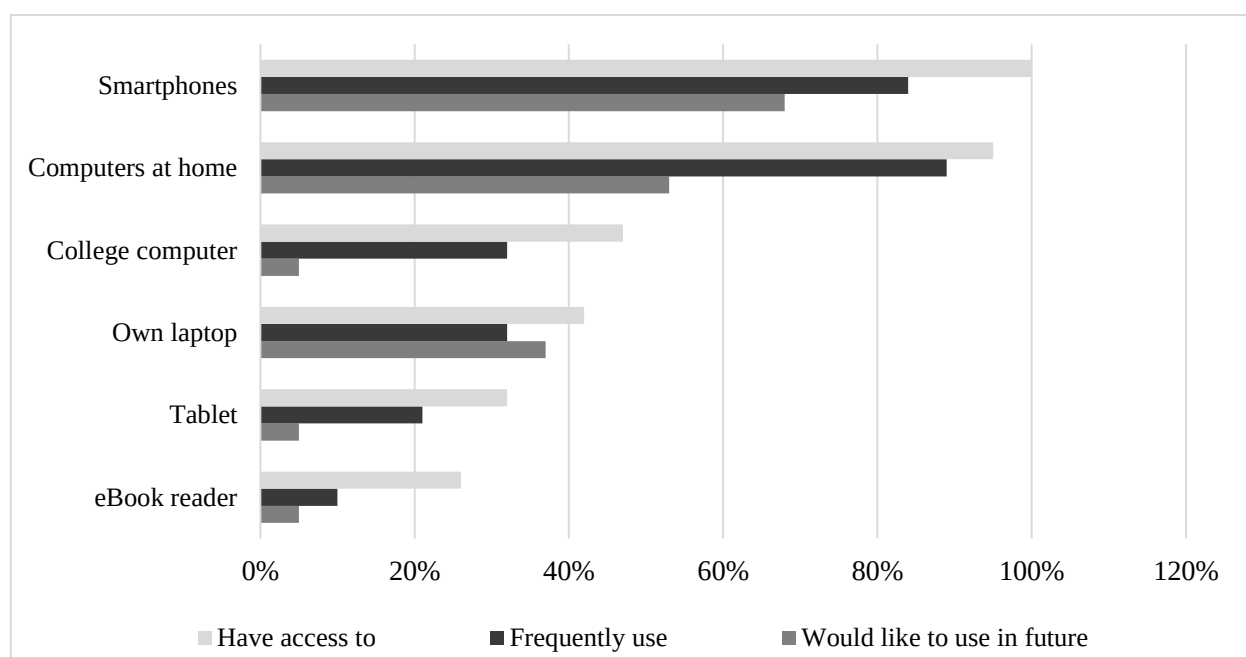


Figure 1: Participants' access to technology at college and at home.

The participants reported spending an average total of 4.3 hours a day online, with quite a range between the most and least online activity (1-8 hours/day; SD 1.8). However, they claimed that their use of digital devices for college work was limited to zero to 12 hours per week (mean 5.8 hours, SD 3.8). E-mail and face-to-face meetings were the most preferred ways to communicate with the teachers (68% of students mentioned these). In addition, 41%

of the students thought that face-to-face meetings were more helpful than emails. Collaborative/conferencing technologies and Twitter were the least used digital tools to communicate with the teachers. Figure 2 shows students' use of different digital tools for non-educational purposes based on frequency of use.

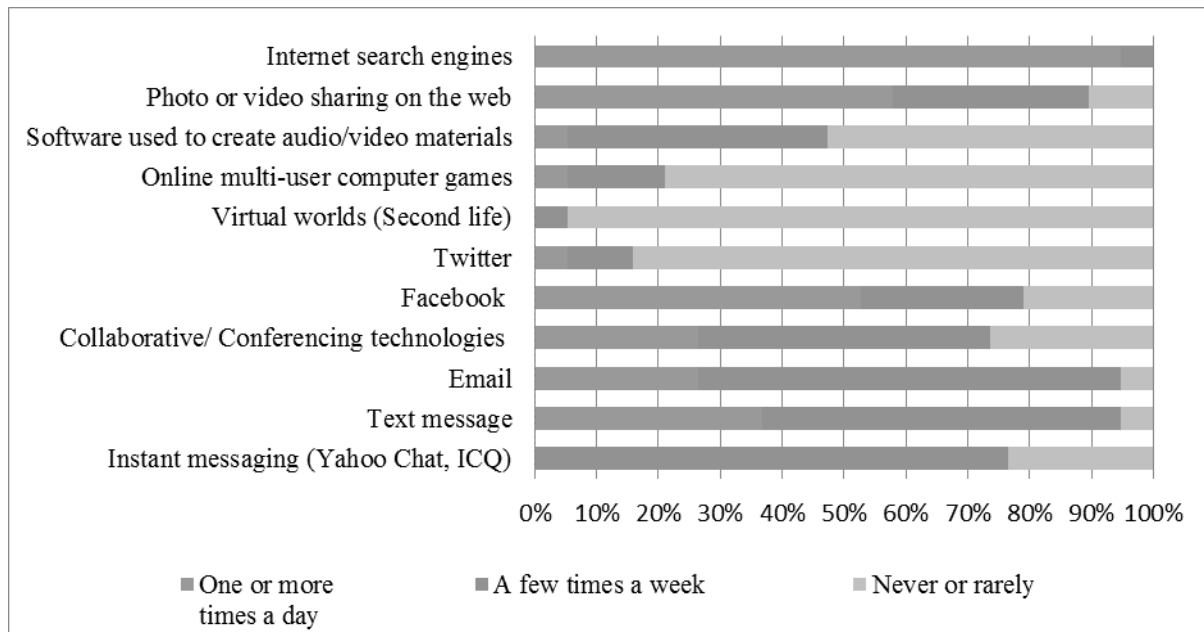


Figure 2: Use of digital tools for non-educational purposes.

Looking at Figure 3, it was interesting to note that internet search engines were used daily by more than 80% of the students to find information. On the other hand, Wikipedia was mostly used on a weekly basis. More than 40% of the students mentioned that they never used web conferencing or video chat for educational purposes.

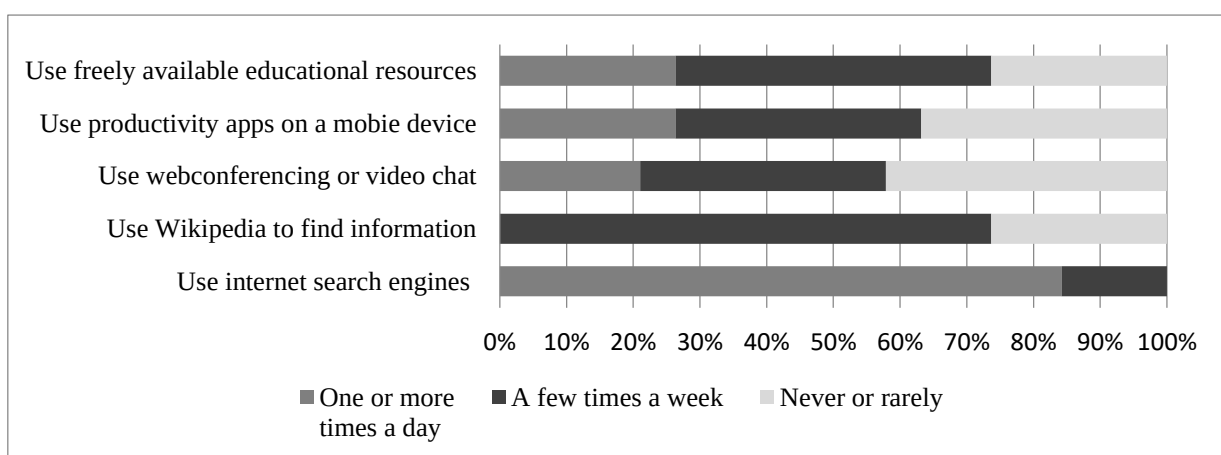


Figure 3. Use of digital tools for educational purposes.

Moreover, students mentioned a variety of future preferences for using digital tools for their college courses. Internet search engines and freely available educational resources were the most common digital tools highly preferred by the students for future use. More than 85% of students also mentioned that they wanted to use video chat on their mobile devices.

Students' perceptions and beliefs about use of technology for language learning

Students' perceptions and beliefs about their own use of technology as expressed in the free-writing and the pre-interviews were analysed in terms of the three major themes they presented: how useful they found the technology to be; how easy the technology was to use; and how important the need for training in the use of the technology was. Students' were also asked questions about their practices in the use of MS Word before they began the training programme.

Perceived usefulness: Participants reported perceiving technology as a very important tool which can make things easy: *"It (technology) may provide people with different and more effective ways to solve problems; it could help people communicate with other people"*. For students, technology meant *"a lot of information in a small machine"* which had the ability to make their *"daily lives more convenient and highly efficient"*.

Perceived ease of use: Students expressed a very positive attitude towards the use of technology for learning the English language. The most common benefits for using technology for language learning was its flexibility. One student stated that *"you can study English at any time with smartphones, laptops or iPads."* Ease of access was another aspect of using technology; *"digital technology is important because it is everywhere"*. *"It is very convenient to use smartphone or e-dictionary"*. *"We just need a mobile phone, a laptop or an iPad and we can stay in any place, wherever we want"*. Another student explained that *"it is easier to carry an electronic device rather than a heavy dictionary. Besides, the form of presentation is vivid and easy to understand"*.

Need for training: Although students perceived technology as a help to them in every aspect of their lives, they realized the importance of the skills required to better utilize it. They believed that a better knowledge of these digital tools could help them save time which could then be applied to other areas. One student commented, *"I think that when technology is used in a good and controlled way it can help a lot to improve English language skills. Technology is nowadays worldwide and it can show how to learn better only if it is supervised by an instructor/teacher or any person able to check how good it is working"*. In addition, one student stated that it was convenient to learn English with technology because he had

unlimited access, but he also added that he did not get synchronous feedback.

Current use of MS Word: Another purpose of the pre-training interviews was to establish how much information about MS Word students possessed and, if they were already using this application, what the level of their usage was. When asked about how often they used MS Word for writing in English, most of the students stated that they did not use it much, and particularly not in English. One student commented, *“I rarely use these functions in typing English because I rarely type English on the computer. I usually write by hand. I use Microsoft Word at my work and write articles in Chinese”*. One reason for this is that the participants’ recent writing in English before coming to New Zealand had been to pass the IELTS test which is a pen-and-paper exam.

Some students had learned to use some features of MS Word by self-study, *“just with practice”*. Besides, Google, video tutorials were a common means of learning about MS Word: *“when I have trouble, I can check on YouTube”*. However, three students mentioned that they had taken a course including how to use MS Word during their high school, and one student got help from her brother whenever she had a problem in using the application. Nonetheless, most of the students said they had insufficient familiarity with MS Word and that they did not use all of its features.

Impact of training on students’ awareness and use of writing aids available in MS Word

This section elaborates the results related to training students in the use of MS Word to improve their English writing skills. Along with discovering how learners felt about their training, we wanted to see if there was any difference in their writing practices before and after the training. Nobles & Paganucci (2015) found that their high school students *perceived an improvement in their writing quality with digital tools and online writing environments versus pen/pencil and paper, especially with targeted feedback and the strategic use of spelling and grammar checking software* (p. 24). It was of interest to see if this held true for these somewhat older English language learners. Writing samples elicited from our participants on day one and day five of the training, using pen and paper as well as MS Word were assessed based on the number of spelling errors, grammatical errors and choice of appropriate vocabulary. These findings are presented below:

The present study did not focus on exploring how much English language was learned by the students; however, the number of words each student wrote before and after training is presented in Figure 4.

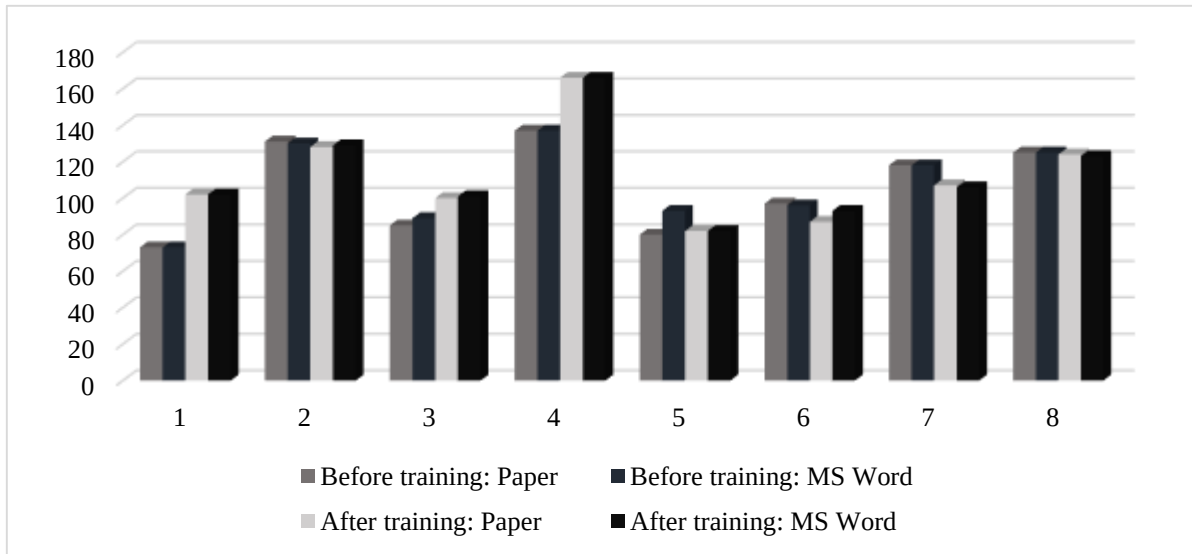


Figure 4: Number of words used by each student.

Pre- and post-training writing samples were also evaluated for grammatical errors based on punctuation errors, subject & verb agreement, use of nouns and articles, sentence structure and use of tenses. When pre-training and post-training texts using MS Word were analysed based on grammatical errors, 75% of students' post-training writing showed a significant decrease in grammatical errors. Figure 5 shows the number of grammatical errors made by each student:

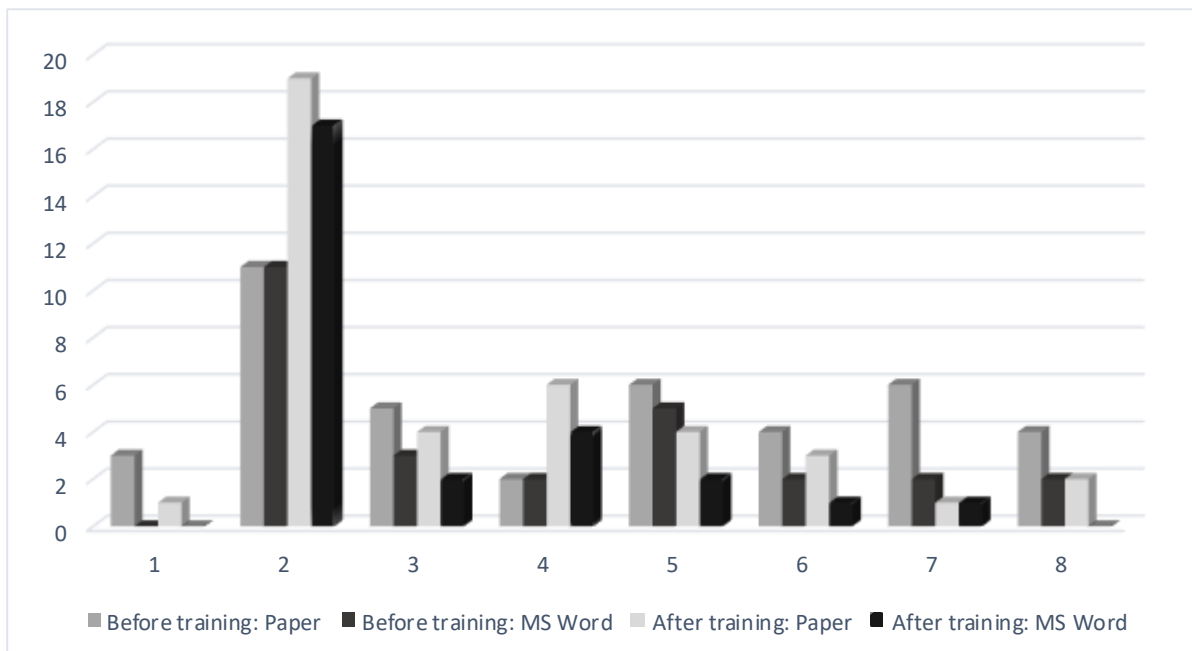


Figure 5: Grammatical errors made by each student.

Although student 2 and student 4 did not show any improvement in the use of MS Word tools to improve their grammatical skills, the other six students made fewer grammatical errors in their after-training paper and MS Word texts. This suggests a positive impact of training on their awareness and utilization of MS Word tools for improving their grammatical accuracy, although numbers are too small for any claim to be made in this respect.

Vocabulary related issues had mixed results. Poor choice of words and use of inappropriate prepositions were the key issues revealed in vocabulary-related errors. Among the participants, only two students' post-training texts showed improvement in terms of their vocabulary and two others did not show much difference. Figure 6 presents each student's vocabulary-related errors:

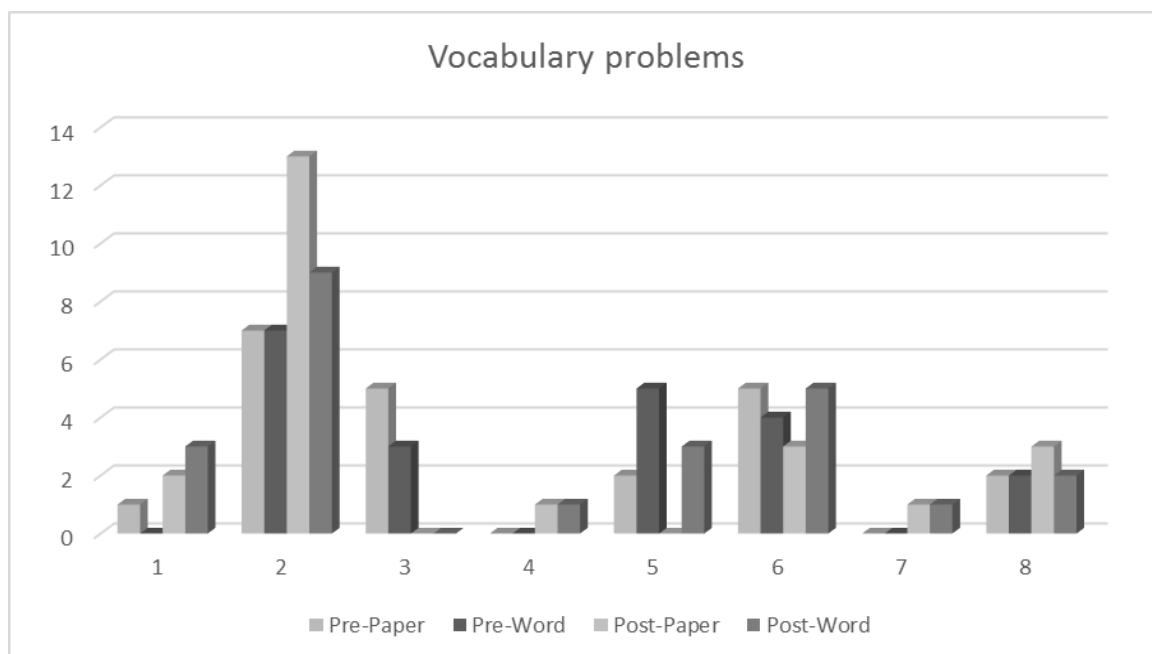


Figure 6: Vocabulary related errors made by each student.

The difference in the number of spelling errors in pre-training and post-training texts showed considerable individual variation. The number of spelling errors dropped in both paper and computer writing after training. Figure 7 shows complete data on spelling errors made by students in all four conditions. Student 8 is a good example of the hoped-for outcome – making quite a few errors initially, and being able to use MS Word tools to correct some errors before training, but all after training. Students 2 and 4 had similar results to Student 8, while Students 1, 3, 6 and 7 were able to use MS Word to repair their spelling errors already before training.

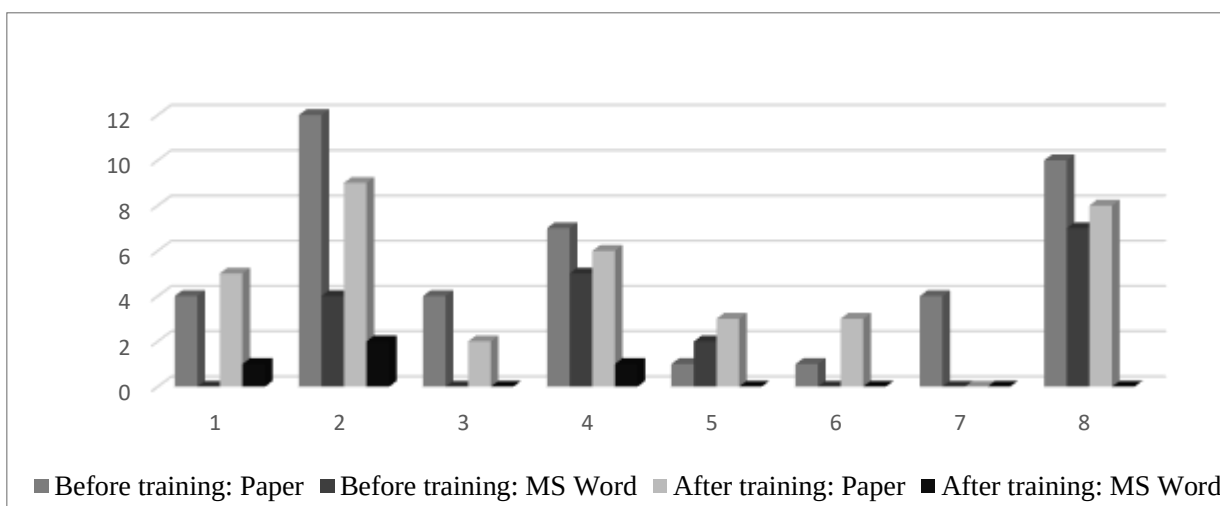


Figure 7: Spelling errors before and after training.

Qualitative findings

In the post-training interviews, when asked about specific features they liked using during the training session, students pointed out that the Translate and Grammar Check features of MS Word were of much interest. Students had used these to translate their writing in English into their first languages to check the literal meanings. One student explained, *“I translate what I write in English into Chinese to check whether its meaning is correct or not”*. The use of the dictionary was also important to *“find a synonym and not to repeat the same word again and again in an essay”*. The Dictionary function was seen as more reliable than what is available on mobile devices: *“the dictionary I use in my smartphone sometimes does not seem correct when I get feedback from my teacher”*. Another participant commented, *“I like the dictionary where I can find similar words. I can change the words without changing the meaning of what I write. I enjoy that more than spelling as I can check the spelling by myself but I can’t understand the words by myself. Here dictionary can really help me.”* Students also used translation when they encountered difficult words: *“Yes, especially unfamiliar words; I translate them by using translator; it is useful.”*

Some students appreciated learning to combine tools, to ensure they had grasped the meaning of MS Word’s suggestions, so that when the program suggested a synonym, they used the dictionary function to check the correct meaning before putting it in the text: *“I think it is necessary to look up in the dictionary to check the correct meaning to make my writing more accurate.”* Another student, like those in Gupta’s earlier (1998) study, used the dictionary to check words he almost knew: *“First, if I want to use some words, but I am not*

sure about their appropriateness, I will check in the dictionary and try to find some similar words to use.”

Students also stated that they felt their writing in English was much better when they used MS Word as compared to the pen and paper versions. They could easily check the meaning of what they were writing as well as diversify their choice of words for their homework, making it more academic. One of the students expressed, *“I think writing on computers can save time. It is effective and efficient. It helps us write more academically by using more professional words.”* Others said, *“I think it will help us write more academically. We use more professional words than in pen and paper writing”*, and *“I can get help from computers when I am writing and when I finish I can get a good chance to check the whole passage and add into my passage if possible. I think it is really important for better quality at the end.”*

Participants realised they would have to write in a word processor for their university studies and were looking forward to it being a more efficient way to write: *“I think writing on computers can save my time.”* Some expressed frustration at being unable to get more information from spell and grammar checks: *“I think it’s useful but sometimes it’s wrong. Sometimes I write a sentence in the right form but there is a red line there, I don’t know why. It’s not useful.”*

Participants viewed the need for training differently: One male Chinese student said *“Yes, I think it is necessary but I can manage by myself”*. A female Japanese student, on the other hand, said *“I would like to get training because if I get it wrong way, it doesn’t make any sense to use technology. I want to know the proper way to use it. Even to use small apps, I would like to get training.”*

Discussion and conclusion

The present study was carried out on a small scale to examine how training in the use of MS Word impacted on students’ awareness and use of the writing aids available in this software. It further investigated the perceptions, beliefs and practices of English language learners in the use of technology for educational and non-educational purposes. Overall, students showed a positive attitude towards technology and were eager to get more training in using it effectively for language learning.

The results of the study also showed that students perceived technology in various forms as flexible and easily accessible. This is aligned with the findings of many studies (Mueller Wood, De Pasquale & Archer, 2011; Richardson, Nash, & Flora, 2014). Richardson, Nash, and Flora (2014) also pointed out a direct relationship between accessibility and students’

attitudes towards the use of technology. In the present study, a smartphone and a computer or a laptop at home were common devices accessible by more than 95% of the participating students and they also exhibited a positive attitude towards the use of technology. Just as has been found in other studies (Strachan & Aljabali, 2015; Swanson & Walker, 2015), the use of internet search engines, photo or video sharing, Facebook, email, text and instant messaging, and collaborative/conferencing technologies were the most common digital practices of the students.

Although these students were already using technology for various purposes, some realized the need for expertise in using the advanced features of these digital tools to gain maximum benefits. Prensky (2001) pointed out that the effectiveness of technology is dependent upon learners' knowledge of technological tools, expertise, and level of comfort while using these tools. Hubbard (2004) claimed that the majority of CALL users skipped tutorials in order to begin using a tool, which was also found true in the present study. The students were already using MS Word, though not extensively; they knew hardly anything about most of MS Word's features. Moreover, their use of MS Word was based on self-study, which was similar to findings in Jarvis (2014) who pointed out that the majority of the users' digital practices were based on individual expertise. However, maximum learning benefits of digital tools cannot generally be obtained by relying on users' personal know-how alone.

Other studies have also found effects of short training programmes. O'Bryan (2008) demonstrated that even short training sessions (three ten-minute sessions) produced an evident effect on the use of help options in online reading materials. The results of the present study showed an overall improvement in the participants' vocabulary, spelling and grammatical accuracy, which is in line with Hubbard's (2004) goal of achieving a connection between learner training and learning outcomes. Students also showed positive attitudes towards training and were motivated to get more in relation to other digital tools used for language learning.

The results of the study also revealed that with the globalization of education, even in developed countries such as New Zealand, language teachers cannot assume that all learners possess similar basic skills in the general-use tools in CALL. However, an evaluation of the digital skills of the students can help teachers in designing pre-course training sessions to maximize their use of digital tools for language learning. Furthermore, the results of this study revealed that minimal educational interventions can lead students to making greater gains in their perceptions, motivation and abilities with digital tools for educational purposes. The present study had a small number of participants and limited time was spent on training the

students. Nonetheless, students showed an increased awareness of the affordances of MS Word, a tool they will always have access to. This finding relates to all language learning contexts, both national and international, enabling the teachers to better address their own learners' needs, particularly when learners are coming from diverse educational backgrounds and with varied technology skills, to learn together within the same program.

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